

Sano: Usability Test Plan

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NYC restaurant inspection history, made readable

Status: plan · formal sessions not yet run

Live app: sano-nine.vercel.app

Goal. Find out whether diners can read a restaurant's official grade quickly, understand what its inspection history adds, and correctly understand Sano's limits: not a safety verdict, not real-time, and reviews kept separate from official data.

Research questions

1. Can people find a restaurant and state its official grade without help?
2. Do they understand the inspection timeline in their own words?
3. Do they read "Inspection reliability 60" as a comparison, not a safety score?
4. Can they tell official NYC data apart from Google review context?
5. Do they notice the data limits before making a decision?

Participants (5)

- 2 Everyday NYC diners
- 2 Cautious diners or caregivers: people choosing food for kids, older relatives, or someone with a weak immune system
- 1 Keyboard-only or screen reader user, to check the WCAG 2.2 fixes with a real person

Recruited from my Pursuit network and personal contacts. Nobody who helped build Sano.

Format

30-minute moderated sessions, in person or over Zoom with screen share, on the live app. Participants think aloud. Four on desktop, one on mobile.

Tasks

- 1 Find a Korean restaurant in Bushwick and tell me its grade.
Success: finds Lucky Chix and says A.
- 2 Describe Lucky Chix's inspection history in your own words.
Success: mentions that the grade has moved around.
- 3 What does "Inspection reliability 60" mean to you?
Success: describes a comparison, not "60% safe."
- 4 Where does the 4.9 star rating come from? Is it part of the grade?
Success: Google, and separate from the grade.
- 5 You're picking dinner for a relative who has to be careful about food. Lucky Chix or Cutwater? Why?
Watch: do they use the history, and do they notice the limits?
- 6 Keyboard or screen reader participant: complete task 1 without a mouse.
Success: reaches the grade with visible focus the whole way.

What I'll measure

Task success: full / partial / fail

Time on task

Misreadings on tasks 3 and 4

1-7 ease rating per task

Direct quotes

Testing so far

I was the sole engineer on Sano. Throughout development, two teammates tested the live site continually and reported issues, which I fixed. Because they knew the product, that counts as informal testing, not usability research. This plan is the next step: five participants from outside the team.

Consent and privacy

- Written consent before starting: purpose, voluntary, skip or stop at any time.
- No health questions. Task 5 is hypothetical; I don't ask about their own conditions.
- Recording only if they agree. Otherwise, notes only.
- Notes in a private folder. Recordings deleted after 30 days.
- No names in notes. Participants are P1-P5.
- Quotes anonymized before they appear anywhere.

Analysis and output

Group observations by issue and rate each as blocking, serious, or minor. Write a one-page findings summary with the top three issues and what I'd change. Make the changes, then re-test.

Timeline

Recruit
3 days

Run sessions
1 week

Findings
2 days